ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Register transformation

Changing register is not replacing everyday words with “difficult” synonyms. It changes what is explicit, who appears as the agent and how the writer manages the relationship with the audience.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Rephrase a message without altering its essential propositional content.

Reframe one proposition for conversational, professional and academic settings by adjusting grammar, agency, density and politeness.

MODEL

Send it today. -> We would appreciate receipt by close of business.

meaning + audience + purpose -> register choices

6 GUIDED STAGES · 28 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

Outcome 1	Outcome 2	Outcome 3
Adapt grammar and tone to audience, purpose and channel.	Control agency, directness and nominal density.	Preserve the essential meaning while changing register.

Build meaning before form

Reframe one proposition for conversational, professional and academic settings by adjusting grammar, agency, density and politeness.

Register is a grammatical decision

Could you send the file?, Please send the file and Submission is required encode different relationships, agency and degrees of directness. They are not interchangeable synonyms.

Register emerges from a cluster of choices: clause type, modal, pronouns, verb type, information density and stance.

Visible or hidden agency

We recommend testing keeps the recommender visible. It is recommended that the system be tested creates institutional distance. The second is not automatically better; its value depends on whether responsibility matters.

When accountability is central, a direct active clause may be the most appropriate formal choice.

Purpose	Likely choice
show responsibility	explicit agent
state a general procedure	passive/impersonal
request action	clear active verb

Politeness without semantic drift

Please reply by Friday softens You must reply by Friday while preserving the deadline. You might reply sometime changes both obligation and timing, so it is not an equivalent register transformation.

Track modality, deadlines, conditions and degree of certainty before and after every rewrite.

Transform without distorting

The best version is appropriate and accurate, not merely longer. Dense nominal phrases can sound bureaucratic; slang can sound dismissive; excessive hedging can conceal the requested action.

Test the sentence against the real reader: do they know what happened, who must act and by when?

Reason through the pattern

The ladder moves one stable meaning through conversation, professional communication and academic prose. At every step, a semantic lock protects obligation, timing and certainty.

01	02	03	04
meaning	audience	purpose	register choices

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Fix the meaning, obligation, certainty and deadline that must not change.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Identify the relationship, audience and channel.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Adjust directness, agency, vocabulary and density.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Check that politeness or formality has not created ambiguity.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Register	Typical features	Example
conversational	contractions, phrasal verbs	Can you look into it?
professional	clear politeness, precision	Could you investigate this?
academic/formal	calibrated impersonality, density	Further investigation is required.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

Can you look into it?	conversational
Could you investigate this?	professional
Further investigation is required.	formal/impersonal

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Assuming formal always means passive.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Using nominalisations that hide responsibility.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Softening an instruction until its obligation is no longer clear.

Recognition in context

Choose the form that completes each situation naturally.

A1 · CONTEXT 1

Choose the clearest professional request.

OPTIONS Could you send the revised file by 3 p.m.? · Gimme the file later. · The file situation should perhaps occur. · You'd better do it.

A2 · CONTEXT 2

Choose the suitable academic version of "We found out the method didn't work."

OPTIONS The findings indicated that the method was ineffective. · We kinda found it was bad. · The method totally bombed. · It didn't work, you know.

A3 · CONTEXT 3

Which version keeps the agent visible?

OPTIONS The committee rejected the proposal. · The proposal was rejected. · A rejection occurred. · It got rejected.

A4 · CONTEXT 4

Which polite version preserves the obligation?

OPTIONS Please submit the form by Friday. · You might submit it sometime. · Submission could perhaps happen. · No worries if you skip it.

A5 · CONTEXT 5

Choose the natural conversational version of "Further investigation is required."

OPTIONS We need to look into it more. · An investigation requirement is instantiated. · Further inquiry must be operationalised. · It is hereby investigated.

A6 · CONTEXT 6

Choose the neutral, concise version.

OPTIONS The update caused several errors. · The implementation of the update was causative of errors. · The update totally messed things up. · Errors were, like, happening.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Two connected decisions

Resolve two connected choices within the same context.

B1 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 1

Conversational: “Can you _____ this?” Professional: “Could you _____ this issue?”

OPTIONS Gap 1: look into / investigation of / be investigated · Gap 2: investigate / look thing / investigation

B2 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 2

Neutral: “The test _____ a flaw.” Academic: “The test results _____ the presence of a flaw.”

OPTIONS Gap 1: found / found out of / did finding · Gap 2: indicated / told about / were saying

B3 · CONNECTED CONTEXT 3

Direct: “Send it today.” Polite but equivalent: “We would appreciate _____ it _____ today.”

OPTIONS Gap 1: receiving / to receive maybe / receipt maybe of · Gap 2: by the end of / perhaps after / whenever after

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided text

Maintain the target structure throughout a complete text.

C1 · GUIDED APPLICATION

Informal draft: “Hey, you forgot the numbers. Send them now so we can sort this out.” Professional version: “It _____ that the figures were omitted. Could you _____ them by noon so that we can _____ the issue today? We would _____ your prompt response.”

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

appears · appreciate · be appreciating of · is forgetting · like maybe · resolution of · resolve · send · sending · sort of fix · submission · totally looks

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open text

Supply every form without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT APPLICATION

Conversational -> professional: “Can you look over this?” -> _____. Professional -> academic: “We checked the results.” -> _____. Formal -> conversational: “Immediate action is required.” -> _____. Preserve the obligation: “You must reply by Friday.” -> _____. Make the agent visible: “The request was rejected.” -> _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled production

Transform the idea without changing its meaning.

E1 · CONTROLLED TASK 1

Rewrite professionally: Send me the contract now.

_____
_____

E2 · CONTROLLED TASK 2

Rewrite in an academic register: We found that people liked the new design.

_____
_____

E3 · CONTROLLED TASK 3

Rewrite conversationally: The postponement of the meeting was necessitated by adverse conditions.

_____
_____

E4 · CONTROLLED TASK 4

Write an original Register transformation response for context 4. Include please provide, by noon.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative mission

Use the structure in original responses and realistic situations.

F1 · COMMUNICATION TASK 1

Write an original Register transformation response for context 1. Include can you, could you, is required.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · COMMUNICATION TASK 2

Write an original Register transformation response for context 2. Include project team missed.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · COMMUNICATION TASK 3

Write an original Register transformation response for context 3. Include please submit, by 5 p.m..

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: audience.

_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: agency.

_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: directness.

_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: equivalence.

_____
_____

R5 · REVIEW FOCUS

Apply this decision to a new example, then justify it: Fix the meaning, obligation, certainty and deadline that must not change..

_____
_____

R6 · REVIEW FOCUS

Apply this decision to a new example, then justify it: Identify the relationship, audience and channel..

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

Could you send the revised file by 3 p.m.?

Use “Could you send the revised file by 3 p.m.?”. Fix the meaning, obligation, certainty and deadline that must not change.

A2

The findings indicated that the method was ineffective.

Use “The findings indicated that the method was ineffective.”. Identify the relationship, audience and channel.

A3

The committee rejected the proposal.

Use “The committee rejected the proposal.”. Adjust directness, agency, vocabulary and density.

A4

Please submit the form by Friday.

Use “Please submit the form by Friday.”. Check that politeness or formality has not created ambiguity.

A5

We need to look into it more.

Use “We need to look into it more.”. Fix the meaning, obligation, certainty and deadline that must not change.

A6

The update caused several errors.

Use “The update caused several errors.”. Identify the relationship, audience and channel.

Two connected decisions

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

look into / investigate

Use “look into”. Fix the meaning, obligation, certainty and deadline that must not change. Use “investigate”. Identify the relationship, audience and channel.

B2

found / indicated

Use “found”. Identify the relationship, audience and channel. Use “indicated”. Adjust directness, agency, vocabulary and density.

B3

receiving / by the end of

Use “receiving”. Adjust directness, agency, vocabulary and density. Use “by the end of”. Check that politeness or formality has not created ambiguity.

Guided text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

appears

Use “appears”. Fix the meaning, obligation, certainty and deadline that must not change.

C2

send

Use “send”. Identify the relationship, audience and channel.

C3

resolve

Use “resolve”. Adjust directness, agency, vocabulary and density.

C4

appreciate

Use “appreciate”. Check that politeness or formality has not created ambiguity.

Open text

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

Could you review this?

Use “Could you review this?”. Fix the meaning, obligation, certainty and deadline that must not change.

D2

The results were examined

Use “The results were examined”. Identify the relationship, audience and channel.

D3

We need to act now

Use “We need to act now”. Adjust directness, agency, vocabulary and density.

D4

Please reply by Friday

Use “Please reply by Friday”. Check that politeness or formality has not created ambiguity.

D5

The committee rejected the request

Use “The committee rejected the request”. Fix the meaning, obligation, certainty and deadline that must not change.

Controlled production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

Could you please send me the contract today?

Use “Could you please send me the contract today?”. Fix the meaning, obligation, certainty and deadline that must not change.

E2

The findings indicated a preference for the new design.

Use “The findings indicated a preference for the new design.”. Identify the relationship, audience and channel.

E3

We had to put the meeting off because of the bad weather.

Use “We had to put the meeting off because of the bad weather.”. Adjust directness, agency, vocabulary and density.

E4

Please provide the figures by noon.

Use “Please provide the figures by noon.”. Check that politeness or formality has not created ambiguity.

Communicative mission

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

Can you check this? Could you review this, please? A further review is required.

The model combines accurate Register transformation with a clear purpose. Fix the meaning, obligation, certainty and deadline that must not change.

F2

Instead of “The deadline was missed,” write “The project team missed the deadline” when accountability matters.

The model combines accurate Register transformation with a clear purpose. Identify the relationship, audience and channel.

F3

Please submit the signed form by 5 p.m. today; the deadline remains mandatory.

The model combines accurate Register transformation with a clear purpose. Adjust directness, agency, vocabulary and density.

07 · FEEDBACK

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

WELEARN STUDY SEQUENCE

01	02	03	04
complete guide	exercise workbook	answer key	retrieval review

RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.